



Open Source Is Not Just Code

Designing Communities That Actually Scale

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SPEAKER

About Me



Sinduri Guntupalli
Sr Developer Programs
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- ✦ 5+ years in Drupal: developer, then Product Manager
- ✦ Volunteer organizer across Drupal Austria, Drupal Switzerland, and beyond
- ✦ Now in the OSPO team at Dynatrace
- ✦ Building offon.dev, a vendor-neutral community to sustain open source contributors and grow the maintainers of tomorrow



PART I

I

The Burden

*Most projects don't fail on code. They fail
under invisible weight.*



CONTEXT

The Comfortable Myth

- ✦ The myth: success comes from code quality
- ✦ Just ship better code, and the rest follows
- ✦ **Mostly wrong**



REALITY

What Actually Kills Projects

- ✦ Unclear contribution paths
- ✦ Expectations never written down
- ✦ A few absorb all the pressure
- ✦ **Fragile, then it stalls**



REFRAME

A Socio-Technical System

- ✦ A **socio-technical system**
- ✦ Code and community are one system
- ✦ **Community design matters as much as code**



PROBLEM

The Maintainer Trap

- ✦ Work piles onto a few people
- ✦ The hero maintainer burns out
- ✦ **A single point of failure is a design flaw**

Example: Rust

Topic-focused teams (compiler, language, libraries, tooling, infrastructure) each own their area independently. A leadership council coordinates across teams. Ownership is spread by design, so no single person carries the whole project.



PART II

II

The Fellowship

*The work is too much for one person. It has
to be shared.*



FRAMEWORK

Four Levers That Decide Whether a Project Lasts

Governance

Who decides, and how. Make decision-making explicit before you need it.

Contributor Experience

How easy and rewarding it is to help.
Lower the cost of showing up.

Recognition

Whether people's work is seen and valued.
Most community labor is invisible.

Local Community

Where belonging actually forms. Global projects still need local homes.



LEVER 1

Governance

- ✦ Decide how you will decide, **early**
- ✦ Put shared functions under a neutral body
- ✦ Spread maintainer roles across people
- ✦ Give conflict a clear path

Example: Apache Software Foundation

Project management committees elect committers based on merit. Individuals represent themselves, not employers. Decisions happen in the open on mailing lists: if it wasn't recorded, it didn't happen.



LEVER 2

Contributor Experience

- ✦ Lower the cost of a first contribution
- ✦ Give newcomers a clear place to start
- ✦ **Visible** path to trusted contributor
- ✦ If it is confusing, they quietly leave

Example: Kubernetes

Published contributor ladder: member to reviewer to approver, with clear expectations at each step. Good first issues. Mentoring cohorts. A graceful way to step back when life gets busy.



LEVER 2 · FROM EXPERIENCE

My First Contribution

- ★ 2021, during Covid, new to the community
- ★ **45 min** just to open the issue, scared of being judged
- ★ Nobody judged. Community was welcoming

drupal.org/node/3227702

The screenshot shows a Drupal issue page for the title "Add options for Remove Advanced and Target Tabs in CKEditor". The page includes a header with navigation links, a sidebar with issue details, and a main content area with comments and patches.

Issue Details:

- Project:** wysiwyg
- Version:** 7.x-2.x-dev
- Component:** Editor - CKEditor
- Priority:** Normal
- Category:** Feature request
- Assigned:** Unassigned
- Issue tags:** ckeditor
- Reporter:** sinduri
- Created:** 11 Aug 2021 at 15:32 CEST
- Updated:** 1 Nov 2023 at 13:09 CET

Comments:

- #1:** sinduri created an issue. See original summary.
- #2:** sinduri She/They Vienna commented 5 years ago. Status: ~~Needs review~~ → **Needs work**. Patch: `remove_advanced_tab_ckeditor-3227702-2.patch` (1.08 KB).
- #3:** sinduri She/They Vienna commented 5 years ago. Status: ~~Active~~ → **Needs review**.
- #4:** klausl he/him | |they|them German Vienna commented 5 years ago. Status: ~~Needs review~~ → **Needs work**. Comment: "I think this is not the correct approach. I just tested the settings in wysiwyg_ckeditor_settings().

```
'LinkShowAdvancedTab' => FALSE,  
'LinkShowTargetTab' => FALSE,
```


And the 2 tabs get hidden correctly with ckeditor 4.x.
So it would be the best if we make config options for the link plugin in wysiwyg_ckeditor_settings_form(), then users can configure those 2 options in their editor profile?"
- #5:** sinduri She/They Vienna commented 5 years ago. Patch: `create_checkbox_remove_advanced_and_target_tabs_ckeditor-3227702-5.patch` (2.16 KB). Note: "1 file was hidden/shown/deleted".
- #6:** sinduri She/They Vienna commented 5 years ago. Title: ~~Remove Advanced Tabs in CKEditor~~ → **Remove Advanced and Target Tabs in CKEditor**. Status: ~~Needs work~~ → **Needs review**.
- #7:** sinduri She/They Vienna commented 5 years ago. Comment: "Hi Klausl, Thanks a lot for the review. I changed the approach and created a new patch to give users the option to hide/show Advanced and Target tabs for Link plugin. Can you please review again. Thank you very much!"



LEVER 3

Recognition

- ✦ Most labor is **invisible**: review, triage, docs, mentoring
- ✦ Invisible work gets undervalued
- ✦ Record who did the work, sponsors included

Example: Drupal Contribution Credit System

A public record of who did what, across code and the invisible work. Contribution becomes visible instead of assumed.



LEVER 3

Why Recognition Changes Behavior

- ✦ Tie recognition to **real work**
- ✦ Companies get visible standing for what they fund
- ✦ It becomes routine, not a favor

When a company treats contribution as part of the actual work, with real time and budget behind it, the alignment becomes real and it lasts. Good incentive design beats good intentions every time.



LEVER 4

Local Community

- ✦ Global projects need **local belonging**
- ✦ Pair global events with local ones
- ✦ Local events lower the barrier
- ✦ "Come for the code, stay for the community"

Example: Drupal

Pairs DrupalCon globally with local, volunteer-run camps. Small and accessible by design. That's where new people get pulled in and where most new organizers learn the ropes.



PART III

III

The Road Ahead

*What to prioritize, what AI changes, and
what you can actually do.*



PRIORITIES

What to Do Now vs Later

OPTIMIZE EARLY

- ✦ Clear contribution paths and onboarding
- ✦ Explicit, written expectations
- ✦ Distributing authority before the load gets heavy

Cheap now. Expensive to fix later.

SAFE TO DELAY

- ✦ Heavy formal governance and elaborate process
- ✦ Complex tooling and automation
- ✦ Over-structuring a community that is still small

Heavy process on a tiny project can strangle it before it grows.



NUANCE

Good Advice Needs the Right Partner

"Be welcoming to everyone"

Works when paired with triage, so maintainers can keep up.

"Move fast"

Works when paired with shared decision rights, so people stay aligned.

"Document everything"

Works when paired with clear ownership, so the docs stay current.

Context decides whether a practice helps. The practices aren't the problem; the pairing is.



AI

Help and Hazard

WHERE AI HELPS

- ★ Lowers the barrier to a first contribution
- ★ Speeds up docs, translation, and issue triage
- ★ Could ease the "privilege of free time" open source depends on

WHERE AI STRAINS

- ★ Low-effort contributions can overwhelm reviewers
- ★ The cost shifts from author to maintainer
- ★ Access is unequal. AI can become a new privilege.

AI doesn't replace community design. It raises the stakes. Share the cost and skill. Build it into contributor experience.



MENTAL MODEL

Thrive vs Decay

THRIVING PROJECTS

- ✦ Share decisions
- ✦ Make it easy to help
- ✦ Recognize the work
- ✦ Build local belonging

DECAYING PROJECTS

- ✦ Concentrate decisions
- ✦ Leave contributors guessing
- ✦ Let invisible work go unseen
- ✦ Stay purely global

The drift is slow and quiet. That's exactly why it's easy to miss.



YOUR TURN

What You Can Realistically Influence

You don't need to become a full-time maintainer.

- ✦ Document one unclear process
- ✦ Review a first contribution
- ✦ Credit invisible work out loud
- ✦ Help one local event

These are small structural acts. They compound.



CLOSE

Open Source Is Not Just Code

- ✦ The system around the code is what scales
- ✦ **Design it on purpose**

REALITY CHECK

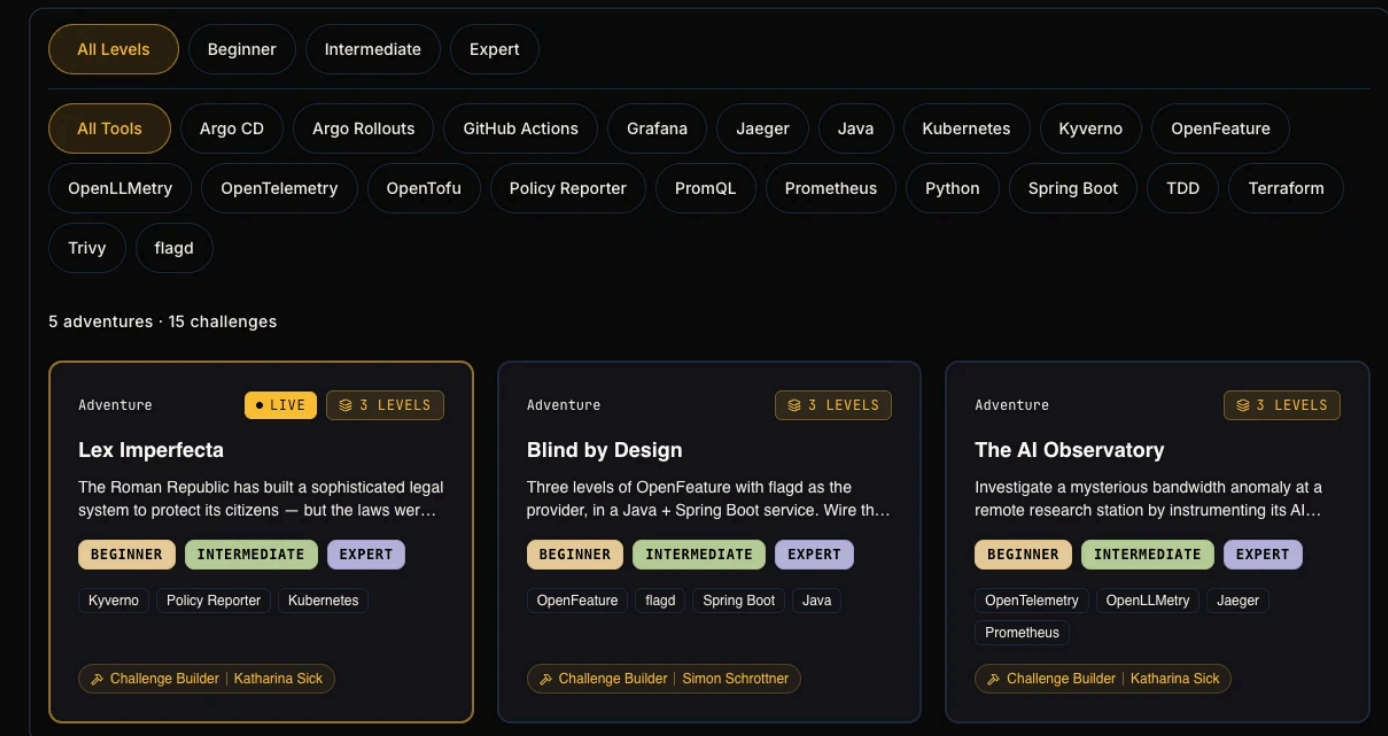
- ✦ No quick fix
- ✦ You control your corner, not the whole
- ✦ Changing defaults is slow, and that is normal
- ✦ **Start with one lever**



COMMUNITY

Join OffOn.dev

- ★ A welcoming space for everyone who loves open source: learners, contributors, maintainers, writers, designers, translators, and organizers
- ★ Built to sustain the people behind open source and grow the maintainers of tomorrow
- ★ **Play Challenges:** hands-on, scenario-driven challenges built around real open source tools. Runs entirely in GitHub Codespaces.



offon.dev



SOURCES

Sources & Further Reading

PRIMARY READING

- ✦ David Hirsch, [Open Source Communities](#)
- ✦ Dries Buytaert, [The Privilege of AI in Open Source](#)

COMMUNITY EXAMPLES

- ✦ Rust, [Governance and teams](#)
- ✦ Apache, [The Apache Way](#)
- ✦ Kubernetes, [Contributor ladder](#)
- ✦ Drupal, [Contribution credit](#)



Thank you

Q&A